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Unit 4

South Indian Kingdoms



Learning Objectives

EQ5L25

- To know the southern Indian states that emerged after the fall of the Mauryan Empire
- To acquire information of the ruling dynasties such as Pallavas, Chalukyas and Rashtrakutas and their domains
- To understand their contribution to society and culture with reference to literature, art and architecture
- To become familiar with the artistic and architectural splendour of Mamallapuram shore temple, Ellora monuments and Elephanta cave temples

South Indian Kingdoms

By the early 7th century, synchronising with the Harsha's reign in the north, the far south had come under the control of the Pallava kings of Kanchipuram. Pallava sovereignty included the domains of the Cholas and the Pandyas. The latter were then emerging as ruling dynasties in their respective river valley regions. Much of the central and eastern Deccan was under the Chalukyas of Badami (Vatapi), who were then pushed away by the Rashtrakutas. The medieval period in India was marked by thee mergence of regional centres of power. There was no single imperial power like Mauryas or Guptas who exercised control over the greater part of India in this period.

The Pallavas

The Pallava kings ruled around the prosperous agrarian settlement and important trade centre of Kanchipuram on the southeast coast of India. Kanchipuram was well known to Chinese and Roman merchants. From the flourishing trade centre of Kanchipuram, the later Pallavas extended their sovereignty over all the Tamil-speaking regions during the 7th and 8th centuries. The central part of their kingdom, however, was Thondaimandalam, a large political region comprising northern parts of Tamil Nadu and the adjoining Andhra districts.

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